

publisher. Robert learned the basics of music and how to play the piano from one of his school teachers, soon showing an exceptional gift for composition and improvisation.

Charting a course

Into adolescence he still imagined that his vocation might lie in literature. Imitating his heroes, the writers of the German Romantic movement, he had written poetry and a novel by the time he was 16 years old—neither of them showing any great promise. In 1825, Schumann's elder sister Emilie committed suicide, throwing herself into a river. Ten months later his much-loved father died. His mother, who had always disapproved of her son's interest in music, sent him to study law at university, first in Leipzig and then Heidelberg.